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DEPARTMENT OF INFORMATION SCIENCE AND ENGINEERING

Date: 17/03/2026

Project Work Phase -I

Course Code: **BIS685**

Synopsis

PROJECT TITLE:

“Cardio Vision: ML-Explainable Hybrid CNN-LSTM System For Cardiac Arrhythmia Detection”

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Domain:	Deep Learning, Artificial Learning and Machine Learning

CardioVision: ML-Explainable Hybrid CNN-LSTM System

For Cardiac Arrhythmia Detection

1. Introduction

Cardiovascular diseases (CVDs) represent a critical global health challenge, remaining the leading cause of mortality worldwide. In modern clinical practice, the Electrocardiogram (ECG) serves as the primary diagnostic gold standard for monitoring cardiac health. However, the exponential growth of digital medical data has created a significant bottleneck: manual interpretation of thousands of heartbeats is not only time-consuming but also highly susceptible to human errors caused by physician fatigue. While the transition toward This project, CardioVision, proposes a hybrid approach to address these limitations. By integrating Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs) for spatial feature extraction with Long Short-Term Memory (LSTMs) for temporal pattern recognition, the system can detect complex arrhythmias with state-of-the-art accuracy. Furthermore, the inclusion of Explainable AI (XAI) via Grad-CAM allows the system to visually highlight the exact segments of the heartbeat responsible for a prediction. This provides physicians with a transparent, interpretable, and reliable tool to support clinical decision-making and improve patient outcomes.

2. Literature Survey

Several studies have explored hybrid deep learning approaches and explainable AI for cardiac arrhythmia detection.

- Ashfaq et al. (2026) proposed a hybrid machine learning model for ECG-based arrhythmia detection in IoMT, utilizing a CNN-LSTM architecture to improve classification accuracy. However, the work primarily focuses on the Internet of Medical Things (IoMT) infrastructure rather than providing a visual interpretability framework for clinicians.
- Velandia et al. (2025) discussed a variety of deep learning tools for cardiovascular disease diagnosis, highlighting the move toward XAI methods like Grad-CAM. However, the study serves as a systematic review of over 100 recent advances rather than a single integrated diagnostic platform.
- Beck & John (2025) introduced an explainable AI (XAI) framework specifically for detecting arrhythmias from electrocardiograms, emphasizing the importance of visual justifications. However, the system lacks a hybrid temporal-spatial model (like LSTM integration), focusing instead on standard convolutional architectures.
- Durairaj & Selvakumari (2025) developed a hybrid CNN-LSTM framework that integrates genetic algorithms for feature optimization, achieving a significant balance between classification ability and

model complexity. However, the work focuses on feature selection efficiency rather than real-time clinical interpretability.

- Varshini & Dhanush (2024) utilized a hybrid CNN-LSTM model for the accurate prediction of cardiac arrhythmia, demonstrating that this architecture captures both morphological and rhythmic patterns better than traditional machine learning. However, the research addresses classification performance only and ignores the "black-box" trust issue essential for clinical adoption.

From the literature, it is evident that most research focuses on achieving high accuracy through hybrid models or general anomaly detection, while complete systems that seamlessly integrate Spatiotemporal classification, Automated signal cleaning, and XAI-based clinical reporting are still limited.

3. Existing Systems and Their Limitations

Existing automated ECG interpretation systems and deep learning models often focus primarily on classification accuracy while neglecting the critical requirement for transparency in clinical settings. While many AI systems successfully detect arrhythmias, they frequently function as "black boxes" that provide diagnostic predictions without explaining the underlying reasoning. This lack of interpretability creates a significant trust gap, as physicians are hesitant to rely on algorithmic recommendations that cannot be easily articulated or justified in life-critical medical scenarios.

Furthermore, most traditional models struggle to capture the complex, long-range temporal dependencies inherent in ECG time-series signals. While some frameworks are optimized for specific environments, such as wearable devices or IoT sensors, they often lack the robustness to generalize across diverse patient populations and real-world signal noise. Additionally, existing automated analysis tools are prone to high error rates, with studies indicating that nearly 39% of automated interpretations contain false-positives or false-negatives, necessitating constant manual verification.

Another major limitation is the absence of a unified, end-to-end platform that combines advanced signal denoising, spatiotemporal classification, and explainable AI-based reporting in a single interactive interface. CardioVision addresses these gaps by integrating a Hybrid CNN-LSTM architecture with Grad-CAM visualization, providing clinicians not only with accurate diagnoses but also with the visual evidence required to support informed medical decision-making.

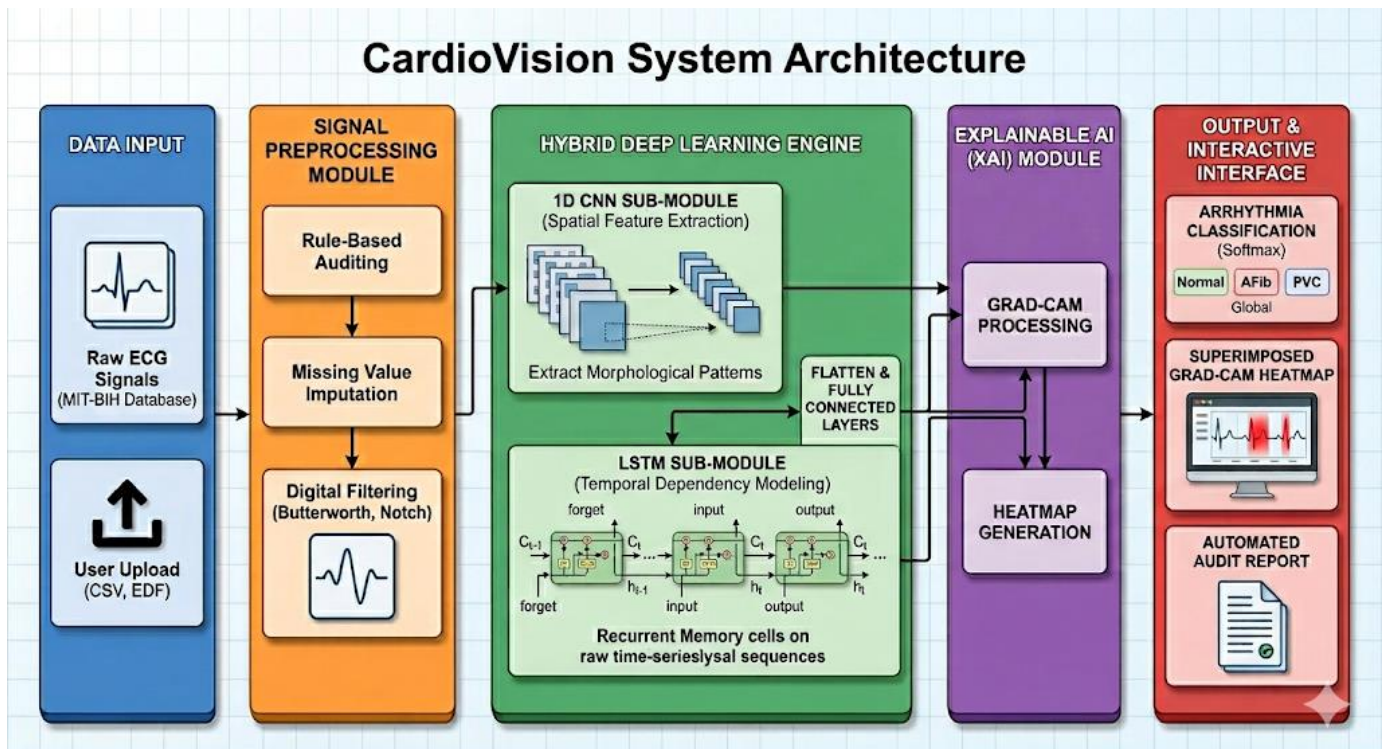
4. Problem Statement of Proposed Project with Block Diagram

Modern healthcare systems rely heavily on high-frequency ECG data for critical diagnostic decisions and longitudinal patient monitoring. However, raw ECG signals frequently contain artifacts such as baseline

wander, power-line interference, and motion noise, which can obscure cardiac pathologies. Manual analysis of these extensive datasets is both inefficient and prone to fatigue-related errors, potentially leading to delayed or inaccurate clinical interventions.

Existing automated tools often struggle with real-world signal variability or function as "black-box" models that lack clinical transparency. These systems typically fail to provide an integrated solution that combines high-precision classification with the visual justification required for medical trust. Hence, there is a critical need for an automated, intelligent system CardioVision capable of detecting arrhythmias through a Hybrid CNN- LSTM architecture while utilizing Explainable AI (XAI) to highlight physiological abnormalities for reliable clinical decision-making.

Block Diagram of Proposed System



Objectives of the Project Work

The main objectives of the proposed system are:

Automated Cardiac Screening: To design and develop an automated ECG auditing system for the high-precision detection of cardiac arrhythmia and signal quality issues.

- **Spatiotemporal Pattern Analysis:** To implement a Hybrid CNN-LSTM architecture capable of extracting both morphological features (spatial) and rhythm dependencies (temporal) for comprehensive anomaly detection.
- **Clinical Signal Integrity:** To identify and resolve signal-level problems such as missing data, duplicate

entries, and inconsistent sampling formats within cardiac datasets.

- Integrated Explainable AI (XAI): To develop a Grad-CAM based interpretability framework that visually highlights the specific physiological segments responsible for a diagnostic prediction.
- Decision Support Reporting: To generate detailed clinical audit reports and verified, cleaned datasets that support rapid and reliable medical decision-making.

6. Methodology

The CardioVision system follows a structured, end-to-end workflow designed to transform raw physiological signals into clinically actionable insights.

The process begins when a user uploads a cardiac dataset in CSV, Excel, or EDF format. The system immediately initiates a Rule-Based Data Audit to identify common signal integrity issues, such as missing voltage values, exact duplicate heartbeats, and data type inconsistencies.

Following initial auditing, the Hybrid Deep Learning Engine analyzes the dataset to detect complex arrhythmias and hidden morphological patterns. Unlike standard systems, CardioVision utilizes a multi-layered approach:

- 1D-CNN Layers: Extract spatial and morphological features directly from the heartbeat's shape.
- LSTM Layers: Model long-term temporal dependencies to detect rhythmic irregularities.
- Explainable AI (Grad-CAM): Computes gradients to generate visual heatmaps, highlighting the specific signal segments that triggered a diagnosis.

Once anomalies are identified, the Automated Data Cleaning module performs corrective operations, including denoising via digital filters, trimming signal artifacts, and handling missingness through correlation analysis. Finally, the system generates a comprehensive Audit Report—complete with Grad-CAM heatmaps—alongside a verified, cleaned dataset ready for immediate clinical review or further research.

7. Innovativeness & Relevance of the Project

The CardioVision project introduces an intelligent, end-to-end framework for clinical-grade ECG analysis and data quality management. Unlike traditional systems that focus exclusively on black-box anomaly detection, this project integrates advanced signal auditing, hybrid machine learning analysis, automated noise cleaning, and Explainable AI (XAI) reporting within a single platform.

The core innovation lies in the use of a Hybrid CNN-LSTM architecture, which enables the system to detect complex arrhythmias and hidden morphological patterns—such as subtle R-peak variations or ST-segment elevations—that are often missed by simple rule-based or statistical methods. Furthermore, by incorporating Grad-CAM visualization, the system transforms these high-dimensional insights into interpretable heatmaps,

significantly reducing the manual effort required for physician verification and enhancing the overall reliability of the diagnostic output.

This makes CardioVision highly relevant for modern healthcare institutions and research organizations dealing with massive volumes of physiological telemetry, where data integrity and clinical transparency directly impact life-critical decision-making and the performance of longitudinal health models.

8. Expected Outcome

The CardioVision system is expected to provide an automated and intelligent platform for advancing the quality and interpretability of cardiac diagnostics. It will effectively detect critical signal quality issues, including missing voltage values, duplicate heartbeat entries, and inconsistent sampling formats that often hinder clinical analysis.

- **Spatiotemporal Precision:** The integration of the Hybrid CNN-LSTM model enables highly accurate anomaly detection and pattern analysis, capturing both the morphology of individual beats and the long-term rhythm of the heart.
- **Automated Clinical Refinement:** The system will perform automated data cleaning and denoising operations, significantly improving the signal-to-noise ratio of the datasets.
- **Explainable Outcomes:** As a result, users will receive a verified, cleaned dataset alongside a detailed audit report featuring Grad-CAM heatmaps.

These deliverables will enable faster clinical preprocessing and drastically improve the predictive accuracy of downstream analytics and machine learning models in healthcare environments